

YASH PARDESHI

"Growing up, when I was studying the game, I was always infatuated by the people behind the scenes," says the artist, who was born in and is based out of the city of Victoria in British Columbia. "I didn't want to be the person at the forefront. I wanted to be the one that's actually pushing things forward from the back." Among the producers he looked up to were fellow Canadians such as Boi-1da, Murda Beatz and WondaGurl, who have created chart-toppers for the likes of Drake and Eminem.

Dhillon and Gill are conspicuously absent from *Hit List* but Gminxr says that all is well between them, even if Run-Up Records, the independent label he set up with Dhillon, has "got disintegrated". "I still have lots of music with AP and Gurinder," says the producer. "I respect them both deeply and you never know, there might be more collaborations." Gill, in fact, is part of the long list of guest artists on Gminxr's full-length debut album *Time Will Tell*, which he hopes to put out this year. The others include Jassa Dhillon, Jordan Sandhu, Sukha and Sultaan, besides Pannu and Zehr Vibe, who he vibed with so well in the studio that he decided to share *Hit List* first.

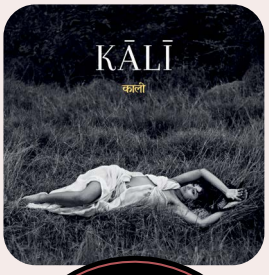
GMINXR'S TUNES ON *HIT LIST* ARE INFUSED WITH ELEMENTS OF R&B AND HIP-HOP, WITH THE AFROBEATS-INFLUENCED 'CELINE' LIKELY TO BE A FAVOURITE

The trio dished out the entire EP over a single 10-hour recording session. "Instantaneously, I was playing a melody, Grewal [from Zehr Vibe] was writing a verse, and Tegi was composing something," says Gminxr, who realised things were going well when he got goosebumps. "Even back in the day with AP, I knew we had a hit when the hairs on my arm stood up. That's what happened with this EP." ■

–Amit Gurbaxani

Most of *KALI*, which includes the five songs that comprised her 2024 EP *Skin*, was made after she went through a particularly "intense" period in her life. Within the span of a year, she had immigrated to Germany; got married; and dealt with a serious illness. She sought comfort in the familiar. "Once I moved here, I [started] missing everything [about India] so much [that] I found solace in my language," says Ditty, who wrote the lyrics for three of *KALI*'s tunes either partially or entirely in Hindi.

The album's most striking song is the title track on which she addresses the systemic racism she's faced in both her birth and adopted homelands. "*Hoon main Kali*," she sings on the chorus before repeating the word "Kali" by stretching it out and then following it with a series of "la la la" vocables. As a result, the line simultaneously sounds like a statement of fact and a declaration of resilience.



The album's title track addresses the systemic racism Ditty faced in both her birth and adopted homelands

"I've worked really hard on undoing the violence done to me," says Ditty, recalling how, when she was a child, she would frequently hear her grandmothers say that it would be difficult for her to find a husband because of her complexion. "The word 'kali' has such a profound meaning. It's also the name of a goddess. That one would use it so frivolously and as a kind of bad word... I wanted to turn that around and say, I am Kali." ■

–Amit Gurbaxani